GLOSSARY

Abiotic Nonliving; often used to refer to the nonliving components of an ecosystem (such as climate and temperature).

Abundance The number of a given species in an ecosystem; an abundant species is strongly represented within the wider population.

Acid rain Any form of precipitation with high levels of acidity, causing environmental damage; may occur naturally or due to human activity.

Anthropogenic Originating in, or influenced by, human activity.

Apex predator A predator that is not prey for any other species.

Atmosphere The layer of gases surrounding Earth. It also protects organisms from ultraviolet radiation.

Autotroph A producer; an organism that makes its own food from sources such as light, water, and chemicals in the air.

Behavioral ecology The study of animal behavior and how ecological pressures influence this.

Biodegradable Usually used in reference to waste products, meaning something that can be broken down by natural processes.

Biodiversity The varied ecological life within a given geographical area.

Biogeography The study of animal and plant distribution geographically, and the changes over time.

Biological community A collection of living organisms within one location; when combined with their environment, they make an ecosystem.

Biomass The total quantity of a given organism within a habitat, generally expressed as weight or volume. Also a type of fuel made from organic matter, usually burned to generate electricity.

Biome An area of Earth that can be classified according to the species of plant and animal life within it.